

Ukraine's human capital crisis deepens as 3.42M IDPs and millions abroad strain labour markets, with 62% of businesses reporting shortages. ILO's Local Employment Partnerships and women's labour integration offer scalable solutions. Diaspora reactivation gains traction through IOM engagement frameworks and evolving dual citizenship legislation.

Women's labour integration could unlock 29.4% of economically inactive Ukrainians aged 18–65, representing the single largest untapped domestic human capital reserve amid acute wartime shortages.

RETURN

IOM Framework for Diaspora Engagement and Return Support

IOM's URC 2026 discussion outlined practical mechanisms to engage Ukrainian diaspora and support voluntary return, covering protection, resettlement, and reintegration activities.

Takeaways emphasize community-level reception capacity and coordinated government-diaspora channels.

3R: Directly advances Return pillar by providing an operational blueprint for diaspora reactivation at scale, linking IOM infrastructure to national recovery planning.

UKRAINE.IOM.INT

Dual Citizenship Pathways Opening for Diaspora Returnees in 2026

Ukraine's evolving 2026 citizenship legislation outlines eligibility stages for investors, expats, and diaspora returnees, including marriage, descent, and investment grounds. Clearer legal pathways reduce barriers to physical and civic return for Ukrainians abroad.

3R: Legal clarity on dual citizenship is a critical enabler for diaspora return decisions, directly reducing one of the top administrative friction points.

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4.2 Million Returnees Signal Scale of Reintegration Challenge

NRC reports 4.2 million returnees in Ukraine as of May 2026 alongside 3.42 million IDPs, warning that recovery risks leaving millions behind. Returnees face inadequate housing, services, and livelihood support, threatening sustainable reintegration.

3R: Highlights that return volumes are significant but quality of reintegration is failing — human capital cannot be recaptured without adequate reception systems.

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RECRUIT

ILO LEP4WORK: Reskilling and Employment Support Across Regions

ILO's LEP4WORK program delivers reskilling, employment support, and grant assistance for businesses through Kyiv Regional Employment partnerships. It connects employers' skill needs with training pipelines, offering a replicable model for filling critical labour gaps.

3R: Core Recruit mechanism: demand-driven reskilling directly addresses skill gap mismatches identified by employers, accelerating workforce reactivation.

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Local Employment Partnerships Strengthen Labour Market Recovery

ILO's Local Employment Partnership approach creates jobs and addresses skills shortages in Ukrainian communities by aligning vocational training with employer demand. Partnerships operate at municipal level, enabling tailored responses to local labour market conditions.

3R: Demonstrates scalable Recruit infrastructure: municipally-anchored skill partnerships are replicable across Ukraine's diverse regional labour markets.

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Mykolaiv & Odesa: Demand-Driven Skilling Addresses Employer Needs

ILO's southern Ukraine LEP targets employers in Mykolaiv and Odesa with skilling, upskilling, and reskilling aligned to actual vacancies. Social dialogue development ensures training investments match real labour demand rather than supply-side assumptions.

3R: Targeted regional Recruit action in conflict-affected southern oblasts, where labour market disruption is most acute and employer-led training is critical.

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ILO LEP: Employer-Led Training and Vocational Education Updates

ILO's action report details employer-led training, reskilling initiatives, and vocational education curriculum updates within LEP frameworks. The approach integrates private sector needs into public training systems, reducing structural mismatches in Ukraine's wartime labour market.

3R: Systemic Recruit enabler: updating vocational curricula to employer specifications creates durable pipelines rather than one-off training interventions.

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Women's Labour Integration: Unlocking Ukraine's Largest Inactive Reserve

With 62% of Ukrainian enterprises reporting labour shortages in December 2025, VoxUkraine identifies women as the key untapped workforce. Targeted activation policies could significantly expand labour supply without relying solely on return or recruitment from abroad.

3R: High-impact Recruit signal: women represent the fastest accessible domestic labour pool, reducing dependence on slower diaspora return pipelines.

VOXUKRAINE.ORG

29.4% Economic Inactivity Rate: Quantifying Women's Workforce Potential

VoxUkraine's PDF report quantifies that 29.4% of Ukrainians aged 18–65 are economically inactive. Modelling shows women's labour integration could deliver significant GDP uplift, making gender-targeted activation the highest-ROI near-term human capital intervention available.

3R: Provides the quantitative business case for women-focused Recruit strategies, enabling evidence-based policy prioritization by government and donors.

VOXUKRAINE.ORG

RETAIN

NRC Warning: Recovery Model May Entrench Displacement, Not Reverse It

NRC's report warns that Ukraine's current recovery approach risks leaving 3.42M IDPs and returnees without adequate support, potentially triggering secondary displacement or re-emigration. Without inclusive recovery, retained populations may choose to leave again.

3R: Critical Retain risk: inadequate IDP and returnee support systems undermine retention gains and can reverse human capital recovery progress.

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GLOBAL CONTEXT

Cedos Guide to Third Places in Cultural Institutions During Wartime

Cedos developed a guide for creating third places — informal community spaces — in cultural institutions during wartime Ukraine. These spaces support social cohesion, mental health, and community belonging, addressing softer factors that influence people's decisions to stay or leave.

3R: Indirect Retain factor: quality of community life and social infrastructure affects emigration decisions; third places build rootedness that supports human capital retention.

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